

Make Your Web Pages Livelier with Jekyll

GitHub Pages are public Web pages hosted for free by www.github.com. Jekyll, on the other hand, is a simple blog-aware static site generator. This article introduces readers to both GitHub Pages and Jekyll, before demonstrating how the two open source projects can be made to work in tandem to create a wonderful blog.



GitHub Pages is a free service from GitHub for serving static HTML pages from a GitHub repository. It's commonly used for documenting open source projects. Another implementation of GitHub Pages is for hosting static Web pages like personal blogs.

GitHub Pages can serve only static HTML pages and cannot execute other languages like PHP, ASP, Rails, etc. Hence, we will not be able to make database connections.

GitHub Pages for your account could be set up by creating a new repository named *yourname.github.com*. Your page is then available at <http://yourname.github.com/>

Creating pages for a project is a little different from creating a page for your account. A new branch named *gh-pages* needs to be created to serve the pages for a repository or project. GitHub also provides an automatic GitHub page generator, found under the *Admin* section of the repo, for automatically generating pages.

An introduction to Jekyll

Jekyll is an open source, simple static site generator written in Ruby. It processes Liquid templates to generate static Web pages suitable for serving by a Web server. It doesn't require server-side scripting languages like PHP connected to a SQL database. It is also the engine behind the GitHub Pages.

Installation and requirements

Jekyll is bundled as a Ruby gem. Hence, the main requirement for installing Jekyll on your system is having Ruby and Ruby-gems installed on your system. Once your system meets the requirements, installing Jekyll is as simple as...

`gem install Jekyll`

Basic configuration and commands

Once Jekyll is successfully installed, you can create a new blog using the following command:

`jekyll new blog`

This command will create a new blog in the present working directory with the default directory structure needed for Jekyll. Now you can navigate into the blog directory:

`cd blog`

Jekyll has various commands to preview, serve and build your articles.

Jekyll uses the `jekyll serve` command to serve your blog. It has a development server inbuilt to serve your static pages. Hence, you can simply go to `localhost:4000` and see your blog up and running.

The `jekyll build` command will build or generate the static pages by parsing the Liquid templates. The static pages will be built into the destination directory already specified in the configuration file.

Writing a new article

Jekyll can have posts and pages. Both posts and pages should be written in markdown, textile or HTML.